

## Between Duty and Defiance: A Deep Dive Into Nonconformity Using Melville's "Bartleby, The Scrivener," Emerson's "Self-Reliance," and Thoreau's "Civil Disobedience"

In a world led by routine, those who refuse to conform risk not only rejection but erasure. Melville believes nonconformity is harmful to others and can lead to conviction. Emerson further explains why society might not enjoy dissent and its preference for stability. On the contrary, Thoreau thinks nonconformity trumps conducting business and exposes useless duties. His statements could be used to support Bartleby's decisions, as they align well with his sentiment. Using negative characterization in Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener," the warnings in Emerson's "Self-Reliance," and the statements in Thoreau's "Civil Disobedience," these texts reveal how nonconformity can isolate, harm, and challenge society's expectations.

Firstly, in "Bartleby, the Scrivener," Melville uses multiple levels of negative tones among the characters to convey Bartleby's nonconformity and its harmful impact on him and the narrator. Throughout the whole text, Bartleby appears to have a dull and stubborn impression, often stating on various occasions that he "would prefer not to" (Melville 7) in response to many requests. This sentiment from Bartleby rubs off negatively amongst his peers, with Nippers stating, "I think his conduct quite unusual, and indeed unjust, as regards Turkey and myself" (Melville 10) in response to his refusal to compare papers. The result of this nonconformity from

Bartleby is being dismissed from the company and eventually dying due to being unable to feed himself.

Additionally, Melville also illustrates the consequences of Bartleby's nonconformity using confinement. When the narrator finds Bartleby imprisoned, he describes him as "strangely huddled at the base of the wall" (Melville 29). This shows how Bartleby's nonconformity has reduced him to a lifeless figure being pressed against society's walls. His confinement is used to show the consequences of his reluctance to work. It also shows that his isolation through rejecting his work is not liberating, but dehumanizing. Unlike other characters like Turkey or Nippers, who work through Wall Street with their unique characteristics, Bartleby's deterrence to work leaves him with no space to exist.

Next, Emerson's "Self-Reliance" shows how others may react to nonconformity and why Bartleby's nonconformity might have irked others. In the text, Emerson states that "for nonconformity the world whips you with its displeasure" (Emerson 6). Throughout Emerson's text, Bartleby can be seen dealing with displeasure from the world due to his nonconformity. His resistance to work results in negative sentiment throughout Wall Street, like a ripple in the middle of a pond.

Also, Emerson further suggests that society prefers conformity to maintain stability and suggests that resistance to this leads to exclusion. He argues that "a foolish consistency is the hobgoblin of little minds" (Emerson 7). In this quote, he claims that most people stick with a routine as a form of security. Bartleby's refusal to comply with this consistency places him against both his employer and his environment. What Bartleby sees as a foolish consistency is seen as the norm in the workplace. In Wall Street, routines are essential, and Bartleby's volatility is not seen as individuality but as a threat. Emerson's claim further justifies why Bartleby's peers

become hostile, as his rejection of order makes him a burden to work with in a society that relies on structure.

Lastly, Thoreau's "Civil Disobedience" not only encourages Bartleby's resistance but also suggests that one should not prioritize business over nonconformity. When Thoreau says, "What is the price-current of an honest man and patriot to-day?" (Thoreau 8), he is stating a rhetorical question. The implication is that there is no price tag for being an honest man, and nonconformity is more crucial than conducting business. Bartleby practices this by deprioritizing his work and not conducting business. Instead of endlessly copying documents, Bartleby refuses to contribute to the workplace.

Moreover, Thoreau also encourages the idea that resistance exposes unjust or meaningless duties, which ties directly into Bartleby's refusal to work. In "Civil Disobedience," he claims, "it is not desirable to cultivate a respect for the law, so much as for the right" (Thoreau 5). Thoreau is stating that morals must take precedence over compliance with power. Similarly, Bartleby's refusal to copy documents is his way of exposing what he thinks are unjust or meaningless duties, like a structural engineer looking for cracks in a building's foundation.

Hence, through examining these various pieces of literature, the reader can understand that nonconformity is not a simple virtue but a belief that can shape their relationships and disposition. Melville shows the consequences of withdrawing oneself from society, and Emerson defends the reaction seen in Melville's text. In contrast, Thoreau offers nonconformity as a moral duty and defends Bartleby's actions. These texts serve as a reminder that the consequences of nonconformity not only depend on the individual but also on the society that is experiencing the fallout of those choices. Ultimately, nonconformity lies in the extent to which a person is willing to sacrifice, either to express their beliefs or remain accepted.

## Works Cited

Emerson, Ralph Waldo. "Self-Reliance." *Self-Reliance*, 1841,

[https://books.googleusercontent.com/books/content?req=AKW5QadPjgA74P\\_NJxzQwQhC9s6E0bwwamxMBgm6bPr\\_aSWVJ0y8\\_DeQQAfCA9YniQm1nT4YZHb5rYXQkDTYmd1GYFpbXovF3Q2j1FBSYStKhRkeAJ4WQySVCGifIxs0bvotZIy612T5r1fb5lM-FVB0gf75SOi\\_k0R1YeZHTCDiaqDURunxbNwhyWyWh-r6SULlzh06J](https://books.googleusercontent.com/books/content?req=AKW5QadPjgA74P_NJxzQwQhC9s6E0bwwamxMBgm6bPr_aSWVJ0y8_DeQQAfCA9YniQm1nT4YZHb5rYXQkDTYmd1GYFpbXovF3Q2j1FBSYStKhRkeAJ4WQySVCGifIxs0bvotZIy612T5r1fb5lM-FVB0gf75SOi_k0R1YeZHTCDiaqDURunxbNwhyWyWh-r6SULlzh06J). Accessed 12 October 2025.

Melville, Herman. "Bartleby, The Scrivener." *Bartleby, The Scrivener: A Story Of Wall-street*,

1853, <https://moglen.law.columbia.edu/LCS/bartleby.pdf>. Accessed 12 October 2025.

Thoreau, Henry David. "Civil Disobedience." *Civil Disobedience*, 1849,

<https://blogs.law.columbia.edu/uprising1313/files/2017/10/Civil-Disobedience-by-Henry-David-Thoreau.pdf>. Accessed 12 October 2025.